Twelve Everyday Things to Notice and Date

In Dad's week, in the people who help, and around the house.

Dad is managing at home, and nothing has gone wrong. If something about his week shifted a little, would two people in the family agree that it had? They would if today were written down.

This guide names twelve everyday things to notice and put a date on. Write what's usual now. Later, write what's different, and when you saw it. Do it with Dad where you can; the National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What a change means is a question for his doctor, nurse or therapist. Most of the areas below are ones the National Institute on Aging and the Family Caregiver Alliance point families to. The wording about what to write down is ours.

In Dad's week

1 Meals and the kitchen [1]

NOTICE Who cooks, what a usual day's meals are, and how he uses the stove.

WRITE DOWN A usual day's meals and who made them.

2 Washing and dressing [1]

NOTICE His usual routine for bathing and getting dressed, and the clothes he picks for the weather.

WRITE DOWN The routine as it is now. Later, anything different, with the date.

3 Getting around [1]

NOTICE How he moves through the house and beyond it: the stairs, the walk to the mailbox, whether and when he drives.

WRITE DOWN Where he goes on his own in a usual week, and what he uses or holds. If there's a stumble or a fall, the date, the place and what he was doing.

4 Medications [1]

NOTICE Whether the medicines he needs are in the house, and how he keeps track of them: a pill box, a list, a routine.

WRITE DOWN How he manages them now and who, if anyone, helps. Questions go to his pharmacist or prescriber. Don't change anything yourself.

5 Mood and company [1]

NOTICE His usual spirits, who he sees and talks to in a week, and what he looks forward to.

WRITE DOWN His regular contacts and outings. Later, anything that has dropped away, and since when.

6 Keeping track [1]

NOTICE How he keeps up with appointments, the day of the week and where things are kept.

WRITE DOWN What's usual for him. Later, what you saw that was different and when, with no label on it.

In the people who help

7 Who does what [2]

NOTICE Everyone who does anything for Dad, paid or not, including the small things nobody counts.

WRITE DOWN Name, task and day. Update it when it changes.

8 Changes in a helper's own life [2]

NOTICE A new job, a move, a neighbor who's away more than before.

WRITE DOWN What changed, the date, and which task it touches.

9 What each person can keep doing [2]

NOTICE Whether the help still fits into each helper's week, yours included.

WRITE DOWN What each person does now and can realistically continue, in their own words.

Around the house

10 The usual state of things [1]

NOTICE How the kitchen, the mail, the laundry and the yard normally look.

WRITE DOWN What's normal for him. Later, what's different, and the date.

11 The rooms and stairs he uses

NOTICE The parts of the house in daily use and how he uses them: the stairs, the tub or shower, the back steps.

WRITE DOWN What he uses now. Later, any room or stairway he's stopped using.

12 Things added or moved

NOTICE A grab bar, a different chair, a lamp left on at night, a bed moved downstairs.

WRITE DOWN What changed, when, and whose idea it was.

When a note isn't enough

This page is for ordinary weeks. If something you notice concerns you about Dad's physical or mental health, that's more than a note. The National Institute on Aging's advice is to suggest a visit to a health care provider. It also helps to ask his doctor, ahead of time, which changes they'd want to hear about. An emergency is a call to emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean, how much they matter, or what help Dad needs. The people who assess him say that, and a dated page gives them something to start from.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to notice and how to date it. The care interview gives those notes a place to go: it asks about each area of Dad's daily life in turn, so nothing is left to memory, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources